



Cross-Border Finance Forum for SMEs

Building Africa’s Trust, Finance and Market Access Infrastructure for SMEs

Kigali, Rwanda

August 10 – 11, 2026

Consortium Members			
NET Kigali	Re-bird Belgium	SBPME-UEMOA	Congruence Consulting

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EXECUTIVE MESSAGE

Africa does not lack entrepreneurs.
Africa does not lack capital.
Africa lacks trusted pipelines connecting its enterprises to finance and global markets.

The CBFF-SME initiative proposes to build this missing infrastructure by combining four essential capabilities in one integrated platform:

✓ Trusted Enterprise Certification	✓ Structured Access to Capital	✓ AI-driven Global Market Access	✓ Physical Gateways to International Buyers
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BACKGROUND & ORIGINS

The Cross-Border Finance Forum for SMEs (CBFF-SME) is a consortium initiative bringing together four complementary organizations: NET Kigali, Re-bird Belgium, SBPME-UEMOA, and Congruence Consulting.

The initiative builds on the practical experience of the Salon des Banques et des PME de l’UEMOA (SBPME-UEMOA), a recognized regional initiative focused on connecting banks and SMEs in West Africa. Over time, this forum became a reference platform for SME financing, banking innovation and economic development across the region.

Key Lessons Learned

1. Dialogue alone is insufficient SMEs require structured financing mechanisms, not just discussion.	2. Trust & information asymmetry Banks and investors lack reliable SME performance data.
3. Regional integration opens markets AfCFTA is creating new cross-border opportunities.	4. Matchmaking platforms are essential Structured environments connecting SMEs to capital are critical.

These lessons inspired the creation of a new generation platform designed to move from dialogue to transactions — evolving a successful regional forum into a pan-African platform dedicated to financing and scaling SMEs.

Historical Partners of SBPME-UEMOA

The Forum built a leading public-private ecosystem bringing together states, regional institutions, banks and technical partners. Over its editions, the SBPME-UEMOA ecosystem gathered:

Public & Regional Institutions	Banking & Financial Sector	Private Sector & Associations
Member States' Ministries of the UEMOA UEMOA Regional Consultative Chamber BOAD — West African Development Bank BCEAO — Central Bank of West African States FAGACE FAPSFD UEMOA AUF — Agence Universitaire de la Francophonie	CORIS Banque ECOBANK ORABANK UBA — United Bank for Africa VISTA GROUP BDNDA — Banque Nationale de Développement Agricole du Mali Banque Agricole du Faso	UEMOA Entrepreneurs' Associations ASKY Airlines International technical partners Regional economic operators

STRATEGIC VISION & OBJECTIVES

The long-term vision of CBFF-SME is to establish a permanent ecosystem that connects SMEs with capital, markets, and strategic partners. The initiative aims to position Kigali as a continental hub for SME financing structuring and investment matchmaking.

1. Mobilize Capital Connect SMEs with banks, investors, and development finance institutions across Africa.	2. Reduce Investment Risk Through certification, digital trust infrastructure, and alternative data sources.
3. Promote Economic Integration	4. Accelerate Market Access

Support cross-border trade under the AfCFTA framework across the continent.	Connect African producers with international buyers and markets globally.
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PROJECT ARCHITECTURE — FIVE INTEGRATED PILLARS

The CBFF-SME is built around five integrated pillars that create a complete system: preparing SMEs, financing them, connecting them to buyers, and showcasing their products in global markets.

- 1

Digital Trust Lab — *Trust & Certification Infrastructure*

Provides the trust infrastructure for SME financing by creating reliable digital economic identities. Functions include governance certification, export readiness scoring, and standardized financial documentation — significantly reducing information asymmetry for banks and investors.
- 2

CBFF-SME Deal Platform — *Financial Marketplace*

Operates as a deal-driven financial marketplace where prepared SMEs meet banks, investors, and development finance institutions in a structured Deal Room environment designed to generate financing transactions.
- 3

World Trade IA — *Global Market Intelligence*

Through a strategic partnership with World Trade IA, the initiative integrates advanced trade intelligence using AI and global trade data to identify export opportunities, match SMEs with international buyers, and provide strategic market insights.
- 4

Brussels Concept Store — *European Market Gateway*

A Made In... By Africa Concept Store in Brussels serving as an Economic Diplomacy Platform, Market Access Gateway, Demonstration Space, and Trade Promotion Hub — providing African SMEs with permanent commercial presence in Europe.
- 5

The Financing Engine — *Blended Finance Structure*

Mobilizes multiple sources of capital: African Banks, Impact Funds, Development Institutions, Diaspora Investors — through debt financing, equity investment, guarantees, and co-investment structures from both public and private sources.

CBFF DEAL ROOM ECOSYSTEM — OVERVIEW

CBFF Deal Room Ecosystem

The Core Engine for African SME Cross-Border Financing



THE CBFF DEAL ROOM — CORE ENGINE

The Deal Room is the operational center of the initiative — a transaction engine, not just an event.

Purpose: Structure financing opportunities for African SMEs; connect entrepreneurs with banks, funds, and institutional investors; accelerate cross-border SME financing under the AfCFTA framework.

Functions

- Presentation of investment-ready SMEs
- Bilateral meetings with investors and financial institutions
- Structuring of financing solutions (debt, equity, blended finance)
- Signature of MoUs, LOIs, and financing commitments

Six Supporting Pillars

- Made In... By Africa — reputational foundation
- Digital Trust Lab — risk reduction
- Mobile Network Operators — data backbone
- CBFF Kigali — financial activation hub
- World Trade AI — market intelligence
- Brussels Concept Store — post-investment gateway

WHY RWANDA — PILOT LAUNCH

Rwanda offers one of the most favorable environments in Africa to launch this initiative. By anchoring the financial infrastructure in Kigali and creating a commercial gateway in Brussels, the initiative builds a bridge connecting African enterprises with global capital and European markets.

Pro-Business Regulatory Framework Highly efficient environment supporting private sector growth	Digital Infrastructure Advanced mobile money ecosystem and digital connectivity	KIFC Hub Kigali International Financial Centre positions Rwanda regionally	Government Commitment Strong public sector support for private sector development
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~30 SMEs/year High-potential enterprises prepared per pilot cohort	\$30–80M/year Financing mobilized annually through CBFF platform	\$250–500M / 5 years Projected financing for 150+ SMEs over five years
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STRATEGIC PARTNERSHIP MATRIX

Partner	Strategic Interest	Role	Expected Contribution
MINICOM	Position Rwanda as investment hub	Institutional anchor	Facilitate coordination, SME pipeline, international promotion
National Bank of Rwanda	Strengthen SME finance ecosystem	Financial sector alignment	Regulatory guidance, encourage financial sector participation
Bank of Kigali	Expand SME lending and trade finance	Lead banking partner	CBFF deal platform, financing solutions
I&M Bank	Regional trade finance expansion	Cross-border banking partner	Trade finance and SME financing solutions
Bank of Africa	Pan-African banking opportunities	Regional banking partner	Cross-border SME banking and financing
Smart Africa	Promote digital transformation	Digital ecosystem partner	Support Digital Trust Lab visibility and standards
Ministry of Finance	Mobilize investment, strengthen financial sector	Policy & investment alignment	Policy dialogue, investor mobilization
Ministry of Trade	Expand exports and global market access	Trade policy partner	Support export-oriented SMEs and trade promotion
FAGACE	Facilitate SME financing through guarantees	Risk mitigation partner	Guarantee mechanisms for SME lending
BRD Rwanda	Finance SME development and investment projects	Development finance partner	Provide long-term financing and investment support for high-potential SMEs
World Trade IA	AI-driven trade intelligence	Market access platform	Identify export opportunities, connect SMEs with buyers
Brussels Concept Store	European market gateway	Commercial diplomacy platform	Showcase African products, facilitate buyer engagement

FORUM PROGRAM — KIGALI CBFF

Location Kigali, Rwanda	Dates August 9 – 11, 2026	Core Objective Mobilize financing, trade opportunities and international partnerships for African SMEs
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DAY 1 — Monday 10 /2026
Policy Leadership, SME Growth & Market Access

08:30–09:00	Registration & Networking Breakfast SMEs, banks, investors, trade institutions, development partners
09:00–09:30	Opening Ceremony — Rwanda as Gateway for SME Investment in Africa

	MINICOM · Ministry of Finance · Ministry of Trade – Rwanda's investment strategy – Strengthening the SME ecosystem – Positioning Kigali as a continental finance hub
09:30–10:15	Policy Dialogue — Financing the Next Generation of African SMEs Ministry of Finance and Economic Planning – Closing the SME financing gap – Mobilizing domestic and international capital
10:15–11:00	Financial Stability — Creating a Trusted SME Financial Ecosystem National Bank of Rwanda – Financial sector regulation & SME credit frameworks – Strengthening confidence in SME lending
11:00–11:30	Coffee Break
11:30–12:30	Banking Leaders Panel — Unlocking Bank Financing for African SMEs Bank of Kigali · I&M Bank · Bank of Africa – SME lending strategies – Trade finance opportunities – Cross-border banking solutions
12:30–14:00	Networking Lunch
14:00–15:00	Risk & Financing Solutions — Reducing Risk to Unlock SME Financing FAGACE – Credit guarantees for SMEs – Risk mitigation for banks – Improving SME bankability
15:00–16:00	Digital Economy — Digital Infrastructure for SME Growth Smart Africa – Digital trust infrastructure – Digital identity for SMEs – Scaling African digital platforms
16:00–17:00	Global Market Intelligence — Finding International Buyers for African Products World Trade IA – Export market analysis – Identifying global demand – Connecting SMEs with buyers
17:00–18:00	SME Investment Pitch Session — The CBFF Investment Pipeline Selected SMEs – Growth strategy & financing needs – Export potential – Audience: banks, investors, trade institutions
19:00–21:00	Official Networking Reception

DAY 2 — Tuesday, August 11, 2026

CBFF Deal Room — Africa's SME Investment Marketplace

09:00–09:30	Deal Room Opening — From Dialogue to Investment MINICOM – Presentation of SME investment pipeline – Financing opportunities & Deal Room structure
09:30–12:30	Deal Room Meetings — Round 1 Bank of Kigali · I&M Bank · Bank of Africa · FAGACE – Bilateral meetings: SMEs, banks, investors, guarantee institutions – Focus: financing structure, trade finance, guarantees
12:30–14:00	Investor & SME Networking Lunch
14:00–16:30	Deal Room Meetings — Round 2 Debriefing Session — Next Steps CBFF Consortium – Summary of deals and commitments signed – Roadmap for post-forum follow-up – Announcement of next CBFF edition – Advanced negotiations: financing commitments, partnerships, due diligence
16:30–19:30	Closing Session — Financing African SMEs: The Road Ahead

	Ministry of Trade · MINICOM – Strengthening Africa’s SME ecosystem through financing, trade and digital transformation
	Optional Networking Reception – Informal meetings between investors and entrepreneurs
	Site Visits — Kigali Innovation & Business District – Visits to key Rwandan enterprises and innovation hubs – Showcasing Rwanda’s business environment

PARTNERSHIP OPPORTUNITIES

1. Strategic Anchor Partner Institutional Leadership
Target: MINICOM Strategic Rationale MINICOM’s mandate is to position Rwanda as a regional investment and innovation hub. Acting as Anchor Partner places MINICOM at the center of a platform that directly attracts investors and strengthens Rwanda’s financial ecosystem. Positioning: Official Institutional Anchor of CBFF — Opening ceremony leadership — Strategic visibility across all CBFF communications Key Advantages ▸ Reinforces Rwanda’s positioning as an African investment hub ▸ Direct engagement with investors and financial institutions ▸ International visibility for Rwanda’s innovation and SME ecosystem ROI: Increased investor pipeline for Rwanda; Strengthened positioning of Kigali as a continental finance platform
2. Policy Leadership Partner Public Policy & Investment Dialogue
Target: Ministry of Finance and Economic Planning · Ministry of Trade and Industry Rwanda Strategic Rationale These institutions shape economic policy, trade policy, and investment frameworks that directly influence SME development across Rwanda and the region. Positioning: Leadership of the Policy Dialogue Session — Participation in Opening and Closing Sessions Key Advantages ▸ Platform to communicate Rwanda’s economic vision ▸ Direct engagement with international investors and development institutions ▸ Opportunity to highlight policy reforms supporting SME growth ROI: Increased investor confidence; Stronger alignment between government policy and private capital
3. Financial Ecosystem Partner Regulation & Financial Stability
Target: National Bank of Rwanda Strategic Rationale BNR’s role in regulating the financial sector makes it essential to building trust in the SME financing ecosystem. Positioning: Lead session: “Creating a Trusted Financial Environment for SMEs”

Key Advantages

- Showcase Rwanda's financial stability and regulatory strength
- Build investor confidence in the banking system

ROI: Reinforced credibility of Rwanda's financial sector; Increased participation from international financial institutions

4. Lead Banking Partner

SME Financing Champion

Target: Bank of Kigali

Strategic Rationale

As Rwanda's leading commercial bank, Bank of Kigali is ideally positioned to lead SME financing and trade finance discussions at the highest level.

Positioning: Lead partner of the Banking Leaders Panel — Premium access to Deal Room negotiations

Key Advantages

- Direct access to high-quality SME deal flow
- Positioning as Rwanda's leading SME bank
- Opportunity to originate new loans and financing deals

ROI: SME loan portfolio growth; New trade finance opportunities

5. Regional Banking Partners

Cross-Border Finance Enablers

Target: I&M Bank · Bank of Africa

Strategic Rationale

Both institutions operate regionally and benefit from cross-border SME financing opportunities across multiple African markets.

Positioning: Participation in the Banking Leaders Panel — Priority access to Deal Room meetings

Key Advantages

- Access to SMEs expanding across African markets
- Opportunity to structure cross-border trade finance

ROI: Increased SME client acquisition; New regional financing transactions

6. Risk Mitigation Partner

Unlocking SME Lending

Target: FAGACE

Strategic Rationale

Guarantee institutions reduce lending risk and enable banks to expand SME financing to underserved enterprises.

Positioning: Lead session: "Guarantees and Risk Mitigation for SME Lending"

Key Advantages

- Position FAGACE as a key enabler of SME finance
- Strengthen partnerships with African banks

ROI: Increased use of guarantee instruments; Stronger collaboration with financial institutions

7. Digital Transformation Partner

Africa's Digital Economy

Target: Smart Africa

Strategic Rationale
Smart Africa promotes digital transformation across the continent, making it an ideal partner for the Digital Trust Lab ecosystem.

Positioning: Lead session: “Digital Infrastructure for SME Growth”

Key Advantages

- Showcase digital solutions supporting SMEs
- Promote digital identity and trust frameworks

ROI: Increased adoption of digital platforms; Stronger visibility across African innovation ecosystems

SPONSORSHIP STRUCTURE

Category	Partners	Contribution
Title Partner	2	USD 50,000
Platinum Partner	3	USD 25,000
Gold Partner	5	USD 10,000
Silver Partner	5	USD 5,000

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

Our sincere thanks to all our strategic partners whose commitment and trust make this initiative possible.

The CBFF-SME consortium extends its warmest thanks to all institutions and partners who have contributed their support, expertise and commitment to this initiative. Their contribution is essential to building a sustainable infrastructure for financing and market access for African SMEs.

 Public Institutions MINICOM, Ministry of Finance (MINECOFIN), Ministry of Trade (MINICOM) and the National Bank of Rwanda — for their institutional leadership and commitment to private sector development.	 Banking Partners Bank of Kigali, I&M Bank, Bank of Africa and FAGACE — for their pioneering role in African SME financing and their active participation in the Deal Room.	 Strategic Partners Smart Africa, World Trade IA, BRD Rwanda and Brussels Concept Store — for their technological expertise, market intelligence and pan-African vision.
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ANNEX — PARTNER LOGOS

Note: Partner logos should be inserted below. Placeholders indicate the position and label of each logo as it appears in the original document.

 MINICOM	 National Bank of Rwanda	 Bank of Kigali
 I&M Bank	 Bank of Africa	 Smart Africa

 Ministry of Finance (MINECOFIN)	 Ministry of Trade (MINICOM)	 FAGACE
 BRD Rwanda	 World Trade IA	

For more information or to discuss partnership opportunities:

✉ info@netkigali.com

☎ +250 788 991 551 (Kigali) | +32 487 568 199 (Brussels)

NETKigali · Re-bird Belgium · SBPME-UEMOA · Congruence Consulting